

project.org

TEACHER LESSON PLAN

# Small Works of Power

Grades 5–8 · Art · Portrait, symbol and inscription

James Tissot (1836–1902), Brooklyn Museum

THE 45 MINUTES

| 5 min | 12 min | 23 min | 5 min |
|---|---|---|---|
| HOOK | LOOK AND TEACH | DESIGN | SHARE |

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

## What students will understand

Students will read a coin as a work of art that carries a message. They will identify the three elements a coin designer works with — **portrait**, **symbol** and **inscription** — and explain how the coins of the New Testament used them to declare power and belief: an emperor's face, a pagan god, symbols chosen because a face was forbidden, and symbols chosen to provoke. They will learn how a coin was struck, read the clues that expose a fake, and design a coin of their own that says something on purpose.

SKILLS AND THEMES

- **Visual literacy** — reading image, symbol and text together as one message
- **Design** — composing inside a circle; letters as part of the design; front and back as a pair
- **Materials and process** — relief, the struck coin, and how casting and false dies betray themselves
- **Art and faith** — why Jewish law forbade human images on coins, and how sacred art tells a story

MATERIALS NEEDED

- The coin images on page 3, projected or printed; the exhibition online if you have a screen
- Any coin from a student's pocket or purse, and a magnifying glass if you have one
- Pencils and fine black pens; differentiated handouts, one per student

HOOK · 5 MINUTES

## The smallest public artwork

Hand a coin to a student and ask the class: *"Who designed this? What did they choose to put on it, and what did they leave off? Who is it trying to impress?"* Then: *"Two thousand years ago, people in Jerusalem carried coins that made claims about gods and emperors. Some designs were chosen to cause offense. Today we read them as artists."*

LOOK AND TEACH · 12 MINUTES

## Four design choices

**A ruler's face.** Show the Tribute Penny (a museum-quality replica). One side carries the face of the emperor Tiberius; the other reads PONTIF MAXIM — *High Priest*. The portrait says *this man rules*; the inscription claims religious authority too. Point out how the letters run around the rim and frame the image.

**A god's face.** Show the Shekel of Tyre (also a replica). Its face is the pagan god Melqart. The Temple accepted only this coin for its tax because its silver was so pure: the purity of the metal overrode the offensiveness of the image.

**No face at all.** Show Herod the Great's prutah. Herod's coins carry no human image, because Jewish law forbade it. His designers had to say *king* with symbols alone.

**Symbols that provoke.** Show Pontius Pilate's prutah, minted in 29/30 AD. A simpulum, a Roman libation ladle, on one side; three bound ears of grain on the other. The exhibition calls both deliberately provocative pagan symbols on Jewish coinage. A symbol can be as loud as a face.

**How a coin is made.** A genuine ancient coin was struck between two dies, one for each side. Striking leaves crisp detail and die-stress lines; two thousand years of handling soften the high points evenly. Forgers struggle to fake those marks — which is how experts catch them (page 3).

DESIGN · 23 MINUTES

Students choose a handout. All three levels look at real coins, then design a coin of their own, front and back.

**GREEN LEVEL**
MORE SUPPORT

Label the portrait, symbol and inscription on the Tribute Penny and on Pilate's prutah, match three words to their meanings, then design a coin with a picture on the front and words on the back.

**YELLOW LEVEL**
GRADE LEVEL

Compare Herod the Great's coin, which has no face, with the Tribute Penny, which does. Explain what each design says about its ruler, then design a coin with **no face** whose symbols carry a message.

**RED LEVEL**
GO DEEPER

Analyze how three coins communicate power and belief, critique a sand-cast fake from *Real or Replica?* by its visual clues, then design a coin and write an artist's rationale for every choice.

SHARE · 5 MINUTES

Lay the designs out as a gallery. Each student points to one choice on a classmate's coin and says what message it sends. Close with the question the coins keep asking: *what is the smallest thing you could make that would still say who you are?*

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

**Visit the exhibition:** the four coins of this lesson sit in Cases 6 and 7, each with a magnified view of both sides. Then play *Real or Replica?* — five pairs of ancient coins, one genuine and one fake. All of it is online too.

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/in-their-hands

VISUAL STORYTELLING

The Gospel Timeline sets each of the eleven coins beside its scripture passage and a painting. Nine of the paintings are by James Tissot (1836–1902). Ask students how a painting tells a story over a whole wall while a coin must say everything inside one small circle — and which one they would trust more as evidence.

CROSS-CURRICULAR AND ASSESSMENT NOTES

- **Religion:** Matthew 22:15–22 — *"Whose image is this? And whose inscription?"*; Exodus 20:4, the commandment against carved images
- **Social Studies:** the coins show who governed — emperor, client king, prefect
- **Science:** patina, alloy and wear as evidence of age
- **Assessment:** the coin design and its explanation; an exit ticket — *"Name one choice on your coin and the message it sends."*

SHOW YOUR CLASS

## Design elements, up close

Project or print this page for *Look and teach*, or take it to Cases 6 and 7. The Tribute Penny and the Shekel of Tyre are museum-quality replicas; Herod's and Pilate's coins are genuine.

PORTRAIT AND INSCRIPTION · A FACE AND WORDS THAT CLAIM POWER



Tribute Penny · Tiberius · replica



Tribute Penny reverse · PONTIF MAXIM



Shekel of Tyre · Melqart · replica

SYMBOL · AN OBJECT THAT STANDS FOR AN IDEA



Herod the Great · no human image



Pilate · the simpulum



Pilate · three bound ears of grain

FROM REAL OR REPLICA?

## How a fake gives itself away

| HOW THE FAKE WAS MADE | THE VISUAL CLUE |
|---|---|
| **Casting** — molten metal poured into a mold of a real coin | An unnaturally uniform surface; no die-stress lines; small bubbles; softer detail, like the blurred feathers on the fake owl |
| **Sand casting** — a real coin pressed into fine sand to make the mold | A grainy, soft surface; mushy hair on the portrait; a different edge; patina sitting on the surface |
| **Die transfer** — a mold from a genuine die, struck on a new blank | Flatter and grayer; details lack the sharpness of the original strike |
| **False dies** — hand-engraved copies of the original dies | Artificial wear from a tumbler or sandpaper instead of high points softened evenly |
| **Modern reproduction** — a widow's mite made new | Too clean, too symmetrical; a genuine lepton is crude and off-center |

QUESTIONS TO ASK IN FRONT OF THE CASE

- Cover the inscription on the Tribute Penny with your thumb. What does the coin still say? What does it lose?
- Herod's designers could not use a face. If you had to say *king* without a face, what would you draw?
- Why might a ladle or three ears of grain offend more than an emperor's portrait?
- The Temple accepted a coin with a pagan god on it because its silver was pure. What does that tell you about how people valued the image and the metal?